Coat of Many Colors

By Dolly Parton

INTRODUCTION

Dolly Parton is truly a legend -- one of the most prestigious entertainers in the world; but her childhood was far from the bright lights of Nashville. Her father was a struggling tobacco farmer who never learned to read or write; and her mother, a preacher's daughter from South Carolina, poured her heart and soul into raising the family's 12 children. Imagine raising a family in a one-room cabin with no electricity or indoor plumbing.

She jokes that her family was so poor "the ants used to bring back food they'd taken from us because they felt sorry for us."

Dolly's mother didn't know it, but the day she took a box of rags and sewed them into a patchwork coat for her daughter was a moment in time that became one of Dolly's treasured memories and the inspiration behind one of her most beloved songs.

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(Pg 318-321) Mama began to make me a coat. A lot of times when she made something out of patchwork, she would try to find scraps that matched as close as possible

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so that it wouldn't be so obvious. But she knew me and my personality, so she decided to make my coat out of the brightest, most different colors she could find. This was going to be a colorful coat with no apologies.

It's a lot of work to tailor a coat for a child and line it all by hand, even if you cut it all out of one piece of cloth. You can imagine how much work it took to make one out of little pieces. I knew she was making it for me, so I watched her almost the entire time. She told me the story from the Bible about Joseph and the coat of many colors. Joseph's coat was given to him as a sign that he was loved and special and I felt the same way about mine. I watched how she folded every edge of every little piece under and sewed it with close stitches so that there wouldn't be any ragged seams. When there are so many kids in a family, you can imagine how a mother's time has to be divided up among them. So to see my mother spending this much time to do something just for me was special indeed.

As soon as it started to look anything like a coat, I would beg her to let me put it on, and I would strut in front of the fire in it like some kind of patchwork peacock. I could tell

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the other kids were getting jealous, probably not so much of the coat as of the attention I was getting from Mama. I started to understand how Joseph's brothers got so jealous of him that they put him down a well and sold him into slavery. Aside from [my brother] Denver, I don't know if any of the other kids would have actually sold me into slavery; but I could easily be in for a few spiteful pinches or hair pullings. I didn't care. After all, it was me they were being jealous of – me and my beautiful coat. And it was beautiful.

I remember the night Mama finished it. I wore it around the house until she made me take it off and everybody got sick of telling me (with my none-too-subtle prodding) how beautiful it was. That night, I almost never got to sleep. It was worse than Christmas Eve. I couldn't wait to wear my coat to school the next day. It wasn't really cold enough for a coat yet, but Mama let me wear it anyway. She could see it was no use trying to dissuade me, so off I went down the path, lickety-split. It's the only time in my life I have ever been anxious to get to school.

I burst through the school doors like a multi-colored

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whirlwind, wondering just how many people I could find to admire my coat. I was so proud of it. I wanted to be seen in it. I wanted to be noticed. 'See my new coat?' I said to one boy. 'New,' he sneered, 'it looks like a bunch of rags.' My heart sank a little, but he was just one boy. Surely the others would see how wonderful and special my coat was. My heart sank further as other children poked fun at me and my coat. Soon it turned into a whole room full of mocking faces; laughing, pointing, jeering at me . . . me and my coat. I wanted to tell them the story Mama had told about Joseph and make them understand how special, how singular, how beautiful . . . but they would not hear it.

My heart was broken. I couldn't understand the cruelty, the ignorance that made them laugh at me that way. The teacher came in and noticed I was being picked on, so she tried to help. 'Don't you want to put your coat in the cloakroom?' she suggested, but I would not. They would not shake my pride in my coat, my love for my mother, my faith in myself. I would not have it. I would sit there and be hot and wait them out. I would wait until school was over and walk proudly from the building wearing my coat

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like a banner of pride. I would walk with my head high into the autumn afternoon and show my coat to God. He would know how special it was, how special I was. He did. He liked the way it complemented his evergreens and the rich brown earth of the path. He watched carefully to catch glimpses of it from his side of the clouds as I marched proudly home. He loved the way it looked on his Dolly Parton.

As painful as it was, that experience at school that day was a great blessing to me. It was what inspired me years later to write the song that has become my signature piece. 'Coat of Many Colors' is still my favorite song that I ever wrote or sang. It was also a big hit, and that did a lot to help me forget that early pain. [It goes like this. . .]

(May be spoken or sung)

Back through the years
I go wonderin' once again
Back to the seasons of my youth
I recall a box of rags that someone gave us
And how my momma put the rags to use

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There were rags of many colors
Every piece was small
And I didn't have a coat
And it was way down in the fall
Momma sewed the rags together
Sewin' every piece with love
She made my coat of many colors
That I was so proud of

As she sewed, she told a story
From the bible, she had read
About a coat of many colors
Joseph wore and then she said
Perhaps this coat will bring you
Good luck and happiness
And I just couldn't wait to wear it
And momma blessed it with a kiss

My coat of many colors
That my momma made for me
Made only from rags

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But I wore it so proudly

Although we had no money

I was rich as I could be

In my coat of many colors

My momma made for me

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